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US: TALKS TO END WAR GAINING STRENGTH

UPCOMING DAYS WILL BE DECISIVE, HEGSETH SAYS AS TRUMP TELLS COUNTRIES 'GET YOUR OWN OIL'

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth said yesterday that negotiations to end the Iran war are making progress, even as President Donald Trump signalled growing frustration with allies, and warned of decisive days ahead in the conflict.

"They are very real. They are ongoing, they are active, and I think, gaining strength," Hegseth told reporters of the negotiations. At the same time, he warned that the conflict may be entering a critical phase. "The upcoming days will be decisive. Iran knows that, and there's almost nothing they can militarily do about it," Hegseth said.

Trump's frustration has been increasingly visible as the war strains global energy markets and tests alliances.

US gas prices have surged past \$4 a gallon amid the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, prompting Trump to lash out at partners he said failed to support Washington.

In a Truth Social post, Trump said countries "that refused to get involved" should "build up some delayed courage, go to the Strait, and just TAKE IT," adding that the United States would not help them.

"The USA won't be there to help you anymore, just like you weren't there for us. Iran has been, essentially, decimated. The hard part is done. Go get your own oil!"

Military pressure builds

Hegseth declined to rule out the possible use of US ground forces, maintaining strategic ambiguity as Washington



UAE Presidential Court

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan yesterday received Sheikh Tamim Bin Hamad Al Thani, Emir of Qatar, who is on a fraternal visit to the UAE. The two leaders discussed developments in the region amid ongoing military escalation and their implications for regional and international security and stability.

weighs its next steps. "You can't fight and win a war if you tell your adversary what you are willing to do, or what you are not willing to do, to include boots on the ground," he said.

"If we needed to, we could execute those options on behalf of the president of the United States and this department. Or maybe we don't have to use them at all - maybe negotiations work," Hegseth said.

Standing alongside him, General Dan Caine, the top US military officer, outlined the scale of operations so far, saying American forces have struck more than 11,000 targets.

The United States "continues to destroy Iran's ballistic missile and (drone) capabilities. We remain focused on interdicting and destroying the logistical and supply chains that feed these programs," he said.

Strikes and regional fallout

The conflict continues to intensify across the region. US strikes hit a city housing one of Iran's main nuclear sites, sending a massive fireball into the sky, while Tehran expanded its campaign in the Gulf.

An Iranian attack triggered a fire aboard a Kuwaiti oil tanker anchored at Dubai

Port. No injuries were reported, and Dubai authorities later confirmed the blaze had been extinguished.

Elsewhere, the UAE Air Defence Forces intercepted eight ballistic missiles, four cruise missiles and 36 drones launched from Iran.

Kuwait's Interior Ministry said explosive ordnance teams responded to 10 incidents of falling debris linked to interceptions in the past 24 hours.

Iranian media also reported fresh US-Israeli strikes targeting military bases, a religious site and a cancer drug plant.

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DIPLOMACY AT WORK

China and Pakistan outline 5-point plan

BEIJING

China and Pakistan yesterday called for an immediate end to the Middle East war and urged peace talks "as soon as possible," as they agreed to deepen cooperation on Iran.

The two countries outlined a joint initiative "for restoring peace and stability in the Gulf and Middle East region" following talks in Beijing between Pakistani Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar and his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi.

Both sides agreed to "strengthen strategic communication and co-ordination on the Iran situation" and push for peace. Pakistan later said a five-point plan had been agreed, starting with an "immediate cessation of hostilities" and early peace talks.

The two governments stressed that dialogue and diplomacy were "the only viable option," urging all sides to refrain from force during negotiations. The plan also calls for ending attacks on civilians and infrastructure, including energy and desalination facilities, and ensuring safe passage through the Strait of Hormuz.

—AFP

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Investors bet big on looming 'decisive' phase of conflict

Analysts cite growing fatigue in markets as uncertainty persists

DUBAI

BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

Investors are bracing for a possible turning point in the conflict involving US and Iran, focusing on the potential for easing pressure on energy supply and costs.

Fresh signals that the coming days could prove "decisive" have lifted sentiment, even as disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz continue to restrict the flow of oil.

The shift reflects a broader recalibration. Investors are weighing how quickly the conflict could move toward resolution and what that would mean for supply chains already under strain.

Briefing.com analyst Patrick

O'Hare said expectations that Donald Trump could end the war had "energised" investors, helping offset concerns about ongoing disruption in the region. At the same time, signals from Washington remain mixed.

Mixed signals cloud outlook

US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth said the next phase of the conflict would be "decisive," while declining to rule out the possibility of ground forces. Trump, in social media comments, urged countries facing shortages to secure their own oil supplies, even as he suggested diplomacy may be making headway.

While the upbeat sentiment lifted sentiments for Wall Street investors, with top benchmarks spiking between 1-2 per cent, the divergence between rhetoric and outcomes is beginning to weigh on sentiment.

"There's a real fatigue setting into markets," said Steve Sos-

nick, chief strategist at Interactive Brokers. "Donald Trump has tried to improve the mood through his comments. But at some point, the market is starting to really look for action, not words."

That fatigue is also visible globally. Asian stocks fell sharply in early trading before stabilising, reflecting heightened sensitivity to developments in the conflict. At the same time, oil prices continued to rise, underscoring persistent supply risks tied to the disruption in the Strait of Hormuz.

Rising risks keep pressure on

Brent crude climbed more than 5 per cent to above \$119, extending gains as the crisis deepened. Trump has also raised the stakes, warning that failure to reach a deal could lead to strikes on Iran's key oil export infrastructure, including facilities on Kharg Island, as well as power and desalination plants.

RTA launches self-driving taxis at 2 neighbourhoods

Apollo Go, WeRide services now at Umm Suqeim and Jumeirah

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

Don't be surprised if you book a taxi in Dubai and find it has no driver. The Roads and Transport Authority in Dubai has launched commercial operations of the autonomous taxi service in Umm Suqeim and Jumeirah, in partnership with Apollo Go and WeRide, a global leader in autonomous driving technologies.

The rollout reflects Dubai's approach to adopting smart mobility solutions and its commitment to translating visions and strategies into on-ground projects and initiatives.

Apollo Go and WeRide vehicles are available via the



Uber app and the Apollo Go app in Umm Suqeim and Jumeirah allowing users to seamlessly book their journeys through either platform.

The first phase of the commercial rollout includes the deployment of 100 autonomous taxis within Dubai's transport network, with plans for the gradual expansion of the fleet in the coming years, in line with growing demand for smart mobility solutions and the emirate's direction towards a future driven by advanced transport technologies.

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